



Course Syllabus

ESBM 4570 Entrepreneurial Finance

Section 001: Tuesday and Thursday 12:30 – 1:45 pm Koelbel 204

Instructor: Ellen I. Burnes, Ph.D., MBA Ellen.Burnes@colorado.edu

Office: Koelbel, 464F

Office Hours: In person. Wednesday, 3:30 pm – 5:00 pm, Thursday, 11:00 am – 1:00 pm,

AND BY APPOINTMENT

Zoom office hours (available by appt)

[Zoom Link](#)

Contacting Me:

You may reach me at the email above. Responses may take 48 hours during the week, longer on weekends.

When there is something urgent, you may **TEXT ME** at 720-600-8145. Be sure and identify yourself, and note the class you are taking.

*****This Syllabus is subject to updates based on university guidance or Instructor discretion*****

COURSE OBJECTIVES:

ESBM 4570 examines the financial concepts, issues, methods and industry practices relevant to entrepreneurial decision-makers. The course addresses a variety of topics including financial valuation, sources of funding, structures and legal issues in arranging financing, the private and public venture capital markets, and preparation for, and execution of, an initial public securities offering. Students successfully completing the course will more clearly understand the segments of the capital markets specializing in start-up and growth financing and demonstrate basic financial analysis skills related to business planning, venture survival and valuation. Classroom activities include lectures, numerous case discussions, write-ups and case presentation, quizzes, and a final exam. The class may also have several industry experts in the above areas visiting to reinforce how the learned concepts are applied within the industry.

COURSE MATERIALS:

REQUIRED: Leach and Melicher, [Entrepreneurial Finance](#). Cengage.

We will be using 11 Cases through the Harvard Business School Case program. A link to these cases is available in Course Materials on the Course Canvas page.

STRONGLY RECOMMENDED:

If you have little exposure to Finance, it would benefit you to have easy access to basic corporate finance, financial accounting and managerial accounting texts for reference, particularly when working on the cases containing financial statements, ratios and projections.

To keep the cost of your course materials as low as possible and access to those materials as convenient as possible, we have collaborated with the CU Book Store and the publisher to deliver those materials through a program called "Day 1 Digital Access", which will appear on your tuition and fee bill as "Day 1 Digital Access".

What does this mean for you?

- 1. You will receive access to all your course materials, digitally, on the first day of classes, through the course Canvas page.*
 - 2. You will see a "Day 1 Digital Access" charge on your tuition and fee bill for:*
 - a. This is a guaranteed lowest price, discounted by the publisher, and not available outside this course*
 - 3. You have the option to opt out. This means: you won't pay for anything, but you lose all access to the course materials, including homework managers like Connect or Mindtap*
 - a. You can opt out by: using a link in a reminder email you will receive with the subject heading "Day 1 Digital Access".*
 - b. If you do not opt out, otherwise you will be charged for the materials.*
 - 4. Please keep in mind that "opting out" means that your access to these materials will be turned **OFF**, and you will have no way to complete assignments.*
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ALSO RECOMMENDED:

Venture Deals: Be Smarter than Your Lawyer and Venture Capitalist. Brad Feld and Jason Mendelson.

You will also need a laptop and use of Excel.

PREREQUISITES:

For most, this is not an easy course. In particular, the course is about entrepreneurial **FINANCE** and therefore demands evidence of some eventual competency in financial analysis techniques. Do not take this course if you are unwilling to master the basic techniques of financial analysis. Additionally, there is a significant amount of outside preparation and group work required to complete the course successfully. Entering students should be comfortable with basic finance, accounting, probability and statistics and should be competent with a spreadsheet program.

GRADING:

Final Grades will be based on the following weights:

Element	Number	Points Per Element	Total Points	% Final Grade
Self Intro	1	5	5	1%
Homework	7	5	35	4%
PreQuizzes	10	3	30	3%
Case Follow Ups	10	3	30	3%
In Class Work	2	15	30	3%
Participation	1	15	15	2%
Group Write Ups	2	100	200	22%
Group Response to Colleagues	2	50	100	11%
Presentation	1	75	75	8%
Team Feedback on YOUR contribution	3	10	30	3%
MT1	1	100	100	11%
MT2	1	100	100	11%
Final	1	150	150	17%
Total Points			900	100%

Grading information:

- (i) Self Intro is available in Assignments
- (ii) Homework is developed to support techniques used in Entrepreneurial Finance
- (iii) Case Reading Pre-Quizzes are given prior to the discussion of each case. There are eleven (11) total quizzes and each student's lowest score will be dropped before final grades are calculated. Each quiz is independent work.
- (iv) Case Follow Ups support reflection of material discussed
- (v) In Class Work, there will be two mini projects supporting analysis, discussion and synthesizing ideas.
- (vi) Rubrics for write ups and presentations are available within the Group Case information.
- (vii) Group Response to colleagues – your group will prepare questions for 2 case presentations by other teams. You will complete an evaluation (provided) based on your assessment of the other group's findings and presentation.
- (viii) Midterms typically each comprise approximately 15 questions, with partial credit when numerical calculations or extended written answers are required.
- (ix) The Final Exam is comprehensive

- (x) Individual participation. My primary responsibility in awarding a final course grade is to signal the level of competence exhibited in the subject matter at the time of course completion. This signal is directed primarily to the recipient, but may also be received by those who subsequently view the recipient's transcript. Participation will be evaluated by:
- 1) Student shows up AND displays name tent
 - 2) Student engages constructively in class discussion (including refrains from using phone, tablet, computer or other device other than directly related to class examples (eg excel, ppt).
 - 3) Student is prepared to discuss each case (further guidance and expectations is provided on Canvas in the participation section of Assignments)
- (xi) Consistent with the Leeds grading policy, the **targeted** average course grade will not exceed 3.2. I also reserve the right to apply a curve to each weight or assignment individually.

Grading

I do not negotiate grades. Grades are earned according to the following categories:

% Points Earned	Letter Grade
94%-100%	A
<94% - 90%	A-
<90% - 87%	B+
<87% - 83%	B
<83% - 80%	B-
<80% - 77%	C+
<77% - 73%	C
<73% - 70%	C-
<70% - 67%	D+
<67% - 63%	D
<63% - 60%	D-
<60% to 0%	F

Assignment and Exam Schedule

All assignments are due as assigned. I do not accept late work.

Exams must be taken when they are scheduled (noting approved, University sanctioned activities).

NOTE that FINALS are 12/8-12/12. I will NOT accommodate travel/schedules around final exam dates.

Attendance Requirement:

Preparation for, and attendance at, the case discussion and industry expert classes are required.

While I may not formally take attendance, I retain the option of monitoring compliance randomly with questions asked and attendance lists. Class participation in case discussions is vital to class take-away and, therefore, will contribute to an individual's course grade. Absence from, or inadequate preparation for, case discussions and visits from industry experts will be detrimental to the class participation portion of a student's grade. While students are free to sit where they please each time in the classroom (there is no seating chart), name cards must be displayed.

Syllabus Statements

CLASSROOM BEHAVIOR

Students and faculty are responsible for maintaining an appropriate learning environment in all instructional settings, whether in person, remote, or online. Failure to adhere to such behavioral standards may be subject to discipline. Professional courtesy and sensitivity are especially important with respect to individuals and topics dealing with race, color, national origin, sex, pregnancy, age, disability, creed, religion, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, veteran status, marital status, political affiliation, or political philosophy.

Additional classroom behavior information

- [Student Classroom and Course-Related Behavior Policy](#).
- [Student Code of Conduct](#).
- [Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance](#).
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- [Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance](#).

ACCOMMODATION FOR DISABILITIES

If you qualify for accommodations because of a disability, please submit your accommodation letter from Disability Services to your faculty member in a timely manner so that your needs can be addressed. Disability Services determines accommodations based on documented disabilities in the academic environment. Information on requesting accommodations is located on the [Disability Services website](#). Contact Disability Services at 303-492-8671 or DSinfo@colorado.edu for further assistance. If you have a temporary medical condition, see [Temporary Medical Conditions](#) on the Disability Services website.

If you have a temporary illness, injury or required medical isolation for which you require adjustment, please contact me in a timely way. While accommodations are not guaranteed or sometimes, possible, best efforts will be made.

PREFERRED STUDENT NAMES AND PRONOUNS

CU Boulder recognizes that students' legal information does not always align with how they identify. If you wish to have your preferred name (rather than your legal name) and/or your preferred pronouns appear on your instructors' class rosters and in Canvas, visit the Registrar's website for instructions on how to change your personal information in university systems.

HONOR CODE

All students enrolled in a University of Colorado Boulder course are responsible for knowing and adhering to the [Honor Code](#). Violations of the Honor Code may include but are not limited to: plagiarism (including use of paper writing services or technology [such as essay bots]), cheating, fabrication, lying, bribery, threat, unauthorized access to academic materials, clicker fraud, submitting the same or similar work in more than one course without permission from all course instructors involved, and aiding academic dishonesty. Understanding the course's syllabus is a vital part of adhering to the Honor Code. All incidents of academic misconduct will be reported to Student Conduct & Conflict Resolution: StudentConduct@colorado.edu. Students found responsible for violating the Honor Code will be assigned resolution outcomes from Student Conduct & Conflict Resolution and will be subject to

academic sanctions from the faculty member. Visit [Honor Code](#) for more information on the academic integrity policy.

SEXUAL MISCONDUCT, DISCRIMINATION, HARASSMENT AND/OR RELATED RETALIATION

CU Boulder is committed to fostering an inclusive and welcoming learning, working, and living environment. University policy prohibits [protected-class](#) discrimination and harassment, sexual misconduct (harassment, exploitation, and assault), intimate partner abuse (dating or domestic violence), stalking, and related retaliation by or against members of our community on- and off-campus. The Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance (OIEC) addresses these concerns, and individuals who have been subjected to misconduct can contact OIEC at 303-492-2127 or email OIEC@colorado.edu. Information about university policies, [reporting options](#), and [OIEC support resources](#) including confidential services can be found on the [OIEC website](#).

Please know that faculty and graduate instructors are required to inform OIEC when they are made aware of incidents related to these concerns regardless of when or where something occurred. This is to ensure the person impacted receives outreach from OIEC about resolution options and support resources. To learn more about reporting and support a variety of concerns, visit the [Don't Ignore It page](#).

RELIGIOUS HOLIDAYS

Campus policy regarding religious observances requires that faculty make every effort to deal reasonably and fairly with all students who, because of religious obligations, have conflicts with scheduled exams, assignments or required attendance.

See the [campus policy regarding religious observances](#) for full details.

MENTAL HEALTH AND WELLNESS

The University of Colorado Boulder is committed to the well-being of all students. If you are struggling with personal stressors, mental health or substance use concerns that are impacting academic or daily life, please contact Counseling and Psychiatric Services (CAPS), located in C4C, or call (303) 492-2277, 24/7.

MACHINE LEARNING AND ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

AI can be a valuable tool for augmenting human decision-making and critical thinking, but it is not a replacement.

AI is a tool, just like a pencil or a computer. However, unlike most tools you need to acknowledge using it. Pay close attention to whatever information you use in your own work that is produced from AI, and explain how/what you used at the end of assignments. My recommendation is to screen shot and save everything (i.e., what prompts you used, what answers were produced, where, why, and how). This is new territory, but basic attribution rules still apply. Cite everything, otherwise you are likely violating academic integrity policies.

If you provide minimum effort prompts, you will get low quality results. You will need to refine your prompts to get better outcomes. This will take time and practice.

Don't trust anything the systems says. Assume it is wrong, unless you already know the answer and can verify with trusted sources. It works best for topics you deeply understand.

Use your best judgement to determine if/where/when to use these tools. They don't always make products easier and/or better. At Leeds, we support the ethical and purposeful use of generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Grammarly, and so on) to enhance learning and develop critical thinking skills. These tools can help you better understand complex material, explore alternative perspectives, and improve how you engage with course content.

However, responsible use is essential:

- All submitted work must reflect your own understanding and voice. Be sure to follow your instructor's specific guidelines on the appropriate use of AI for graded assignments.
- AI should supplement your learning, not replace your own thought process or effort.
- AI-generated content may be inaccurate, outdated, or inconsistent with course expectations. Always verify with reliable or course specific sources!
- Use AI tools to ask better questions, test assumptions, and deepen insights, not to shortcut assignments.

If you're unsure what AI use is appropriate, please ask your instructor. Learning to work alongside AI ethically and thoughtfully is a skill that matters both in your education and future career.

NOTE -- Large language models and chatbots are "look back" machines. They don't advance knowledge (yet). ChatGPT-3 uses data from 2021 and earlier (a lot has changed since 2021).

AI is vulnerable to discrimination because it can inadvertently (or intentionally) perpetuate existing biases present in the data it is trained on. For example, if an AI system is trained on data that contains a bias against a certain group of people, the system may make decisions that are unfair or discriminatory towards that group.

There are several reasons why AI systems can perpetuate discrimination:

- i. Bias in the training data: If the training data contains biases, the AI system may learn and replicate those biases in its decision-making.
- ii. Lack of diversity in the training data: If the training data does not include a diverse range of examples, the AI system may not perform well on diverse inputs, which may lead to discrimination.
- iii. Lack of transparency: Some AI systems can be difficult to understand and interpret, making it challenging to detect and correct for biases.
- iv. Lack of accountability: Without proper oversight and accountability, it can be difficult to identify and address discrimination in AI systems.

v. It is important to keep in mind that these biases can be unconscious, unintended and hard to detect, but they can have serious consequences if they are not addressed.

Note: some of this was written with AI; OpenAI. (2021). GPT-3 API. Retrieved from <https://beta.openai.com/docs/api-reference/introduction>. Ryan Gagnon of Clemson University prepared much of this statement.

Computers and Cellular Telephones

Laptops are exceptional classroom learning tools when used appropriately. I prefer that you use your laptop solely for case discussions and note taking. Social networking, emailing, and other multi-tasking is highly discouraged and may lead to a potentially awkward cold call situation. Inappropriate use of the above technologies and others (e.g., tablets, etc.) may negatively affect your individual participation evaluation

TENTATIVE COURSE OUTLINE:

DATE	Class	Topic	Case #	Topic/Case
WEEK ONE				
		<i>begins on Thursday, we do not meet</i>		
WEEK TWO				
8/25/25	2.1	Intro		Intro
8/27/25	2.2	C1 part 1		What is Entrepreneurial Finance
WEEK THREE				
9/1/25	3.1	NO CLASS LABOR DAY		No Class
9/3/25	3.2	C1 part 2	1	HBS: How Venture Capitalists Evaluate Venture Opportunities
WEEK FOUR				
9/8/25	4.1	C2		Key Screening Elements
9/10/25	4.2	C 4		Financial Statements
WEEK FIVE				
9/15/25	5.1		2	Bob's Baloney
9/17/25	5.2			Choosing Your Company's Structure
WEEK SIX				HBS Financing Operations and Growth
9/22/25	6.1		3	
9/24/25	6.2	Review and Summarize		
WEEK SEVEN				
9/29/25	7.1	MT 1		
10/1/25	7.2	C5		Evaluating Financial Performance
WEEK EIGHT				
10/6/25	8.1		4	Tesla
10/8/25	8.2	C6		Forecasting and Cash Management
WEEK NINE				
10/13/25	9.1		5	Bizzy Coffee
10/15/25	9.2	C8		Regulatory Considerations; Fundraising
WEEK TEN				
10/20/25	10.1		6	ViscoTech

10/22/25	10.2	Summary and Review		
WEEK ELEVEN				
10/27/25	11.1	MT 2		
10/29/25	11.2	C9		Pro Formas
WEEK TWELVE				
11/3/25	12.1	PF part 2	7	Bubble & Bee Organic
11/5/25	12.2	Valuation, C10 and 11		NPV and Terminal Value
WEEK THIRTEEN				
11/10/25	13.1		8	Lady M Cakes
11/12/25	13.2	Cap Tables		Managing Ownership and Share Values
WEEK FOURTEEN				
11/17/25	14.1		9	Nanogene
11/19/25	14.2	C15 and 16		Exits
no class	FALL BREAK			
WEEK FIFTEEN				
12/1/25	15.1		10	Strava
12/3/25	15.2		11	SpinMaster IPO
12/5/25	15.3			Review and Summarize
12/8-12/12		FINAL EXAM		